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Universal Credit

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Get an advance or other financial support

If you need help to pay your bills or cover other costs, you might be able to apply for an advance, hardship payment or other financial support.

> You can also check what other benefits you can get (/check-benefits-financial-support). You might be able to get different support in Scotland (https://www.gov.scot/policies/social-security/universal-credit/).

Applying for an advance or hardship payment

You'll need to check which type of advance you're eligible for.

How much you can get depends on your circumstances and what you need the advance for.

The types you can get include:

- an advance on your first payment (/universal-credit-advance-hardship-payment/first-payment)
- a hardship payment if your payment is stopped or reduced (/universal-credit-advance-hardship-payment/payments-stopped-reduced)
- an advance for unexpected costs (/universal-credit-advance-hardship-payment/unexpected-costs)
- help with job expenses (/universal-credit-advance-hardship-payment/job-expenses)
- an advance if your circumstances have changed (/universal-credit-advance-hardship-payment/circumstances-changed)

You must usually pay this back through your future Universal Credit payments.

Get help with upfront childcare costs

If you're starting work or increasing your hours, you might also be able to get help to pay the upfront costs (/guidance/universal-credit-childcare-costs).

How to change your monthly Universal Credit

If you're having financial difficulties, you can ask to change the way your Universal Credit is paid.

You may be able to apply for an alternative payment arrangement (APA) (/universal-credit/how-youre-paid).

If you're behind on your rent

You or your landlord can ask that the money you get for housing is paid directly to them. This is a type of alternative payment arrangement called a 'managed payment to landlord'.

If your landlord applies, you'll get an email or a text from Universal Credit asking you to check your online account. You'll need to sign in within 7 days of being notified and say if you object or not.

Your Universal Credit payments will stop until a decision is made. You might be able to get financial support to help you (/universal-credit-advance-hardship-payment/payments-stopped-reduced).

Find out when you can object by reading the 'Landlord requests' section of the alternative payment arrangements guidance (/government/publications/universal-credit-alternative-payment-arrangements/alternative-payment-arrangements#landlord-requests).

Advice on money and debt

If you need help to manage your budget or bills, you can get free advice (/cost-of-living/managing-money).

You can get help to take care of your living costs (/cost-of-living/bills-housing-health) including support with your utility bills, housing costs or NHS prescriptions.

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